



▲ QUEEN CONCH

The big, heavy shell of the queen conch is lined with a beautiful coral-pink glaze. It can live for up to 40 years, although many conches are caught for food and for their shells. They are also preyed on by many animals.

WOW!

Seahorses have to eat continuously to stay alive—they have no stomach so food passes quickly through their digestive system.

◀ GREEN SEA TURTLES

These sea turtles feed in seagrass beds in warm oceans all over the world. They are superb swimmers, traveling hundreds of miles every year between their feeding and nesting grounds.



GIANT SEA SNAIL

One of the most impressive animals living on seagrass beds is the queen conch—a large sea snail with a shell that can be up to 14 in (35 cm) long. It makes its home in the warm, shallow coastal waters of the Caribbean Sea and the Gulf of Mexico, where it uses its toothed tongue to feed on seagrasses and various types of seaweed.

SEA COWS

Seagrasses are the favorite food of sea cows—aquatic mammals that are related to elephants. They include the dugong and three species of manatees. The manatees live on both sides of the Atlantic in shallow, warm seas, as well as nearby rivers, where they eat a variety of water plants. The very similar dugong lives in the coastal waters of the tropical Indian and Pacific oceans.



▲ DUGONG

The dugong is a docile animal with few natural predators. It feeds day and night, using its strong, rubbery upper lip to dig up seagrasses, which it then swallows whole.

CLINGING ON

Shallow seagrass beds make perfect homes for a wide variety of small fish. They include seahorses, which entwine their tails around the seagrass stems to stop themselves from being swept away by the currents. Seahorses live alongside the young of many larger open-water fish. These hide among the seagrasses to avoid being eaten by larger predators, including their own parents.

► SEAHORSE

When hunting for food, the seahorse waits motionless, using its long snout to catch food as it drifts by. It has excellent eyesight, and can also change color to blend in with its surroundings.

